

I worked every weeknight. I was often given a car and a police radio. I drove around Boston talking to cops and the families of murder victims and people whose homes had just burned down. It was an insanely stressful and tiring—but rewarding—job. I was competing with everyone in my life: my friends were reporters, my boyfriend was a reporter, my enemies were reporters. The *Globe* benefited immensely from these young and hungry interns working all hours for low salaries, but I didn't see it that way. I couldn't believe I was even allowed in the hallowed *Globe* newsroom AND that they were paying me, even if the money didn't compensate me for working overtime and weekends trying to get more clips and bylines.

As long as I could pay my rent, I didn't really care about where the rest of my newspaper salary went. Because the *Globe* money was for an internship, they didn't have us put anything into a 401(k) and I had no other retirement plans (not that I knew what those were yet). The *Globe* took taxes out of the paycheck, and that was it. The rest was mine, and sometimes I even got a tax refund check at the end of the year. Even with all that cushion, it wouldn't have occurred to me to start a savings account (which, oh my god, you should do in college if you can. Why didn't I do that?? Why didn't I know I could do that?).

I don't remember any of my friends talking about saving or having savings. I don't remember any authority figure telling me to save money. I basically never thought about money until I really, really needed it. I was way more concerned with career advancement than with payment.

One of the biggest fights I kept getting into with my dad when I was in college went something like this:

Me: Dad! I got published in my first national print publication. This is a huge deal because it's my dream and also I'm just twenty years old.

Dad: That's wonderful! How much are they paying you?

For someone with such a loose handle on his own finances, my dad consistently brought up payment whenever I made any strides in my career. I railed against this, seeing his constant first question as insulting. That was literally the last thing I cared about. I wanted the eyeballs on my writing.